Get Paid On Time: A Late-Invoice Kit

Short. Practical. Copy and send.

1. Prevent it first

- State payment terms on the invoice: due date, late fee, accepted methods.
- Take a deposit (30-50%) on new projects.
- Invoice at milestones, not only at the end.
- Send the invoice the same day work is delivered.

2. The reminder ladder

Day 1 after due date - friendly nudge:

> Hi [Name], a quick note: invoice [#] for [amount] was due on [date]. Could you confirm when it will be paid? Thanks, [You]

Day 7 - firm:

> Hi [Name], invoice [#] ([amount]) is now 7 days overdue. Please pay by [date +5 days] or reply with a reason so we can agree a plan.

Day 14 - final:

> Hi [Name], invoice [#] ([amount]) is 14 days overdue. Per our terms, a late fee of [fee] now applies. I will pause new work until the balance is cleared. Payment link: [link]

3. Ask why, once

Often the cause is a missing PO number, an approver on leave, or a wrong address. Ask one direct question: "What do you need from me to release payment?" Then fix that item the same day.

4. Stop work on purpose

After 14 days, pause delivery and say so in writing. Keep files locked until payment. Do not start a new project for an account with an open overdue invoice.

5. Escalate with paperwork

- Keep a dated log of every message and call.
- Send a formal demand letter by email and post, citing the contract clause.
- Small claims court is often cheaper than expected for amounts under your local limit. Check your local rules.

6. Make it a habit

Every Monday, list invoices older than 0 days overdue. Send the next rung of the ladder. Five minutes a week beats a chase in month three.

General information, not legal advice. Check your local laws before taking legal action.